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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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U.S. energy renaissance sputters out the gate

Oil, gas firms struggle, renewable projects are on hold under Trump

BY EVAN HALPER

President Donald Trump promised to unleash an energy renaissance that would lock in U.S. dominance over oil and gas. But that is not how things are working out for America's drillers, fracking firms and equipment suppliers, including the company founded by Trump's own energy secretary.

The market value of Liberty Energy has fallen by nearly half since its former CEO, Chris Wright, joined Trump's Cabinet. The company reports it is among many in the industry struggling with the challenges heightened by Trump's agenda, including "tariff impacts, geopolitical tensions, and oil supply concerns."

Three months into the new administration, the price of U.S. oil has plunged to below the drilling profitability threshold of about \$65 per barrel and the industry is ailing. At the same time, the U.S. energy economy is being further destabilized by White House attacks on clean power. It is a stark reversal from last year, when the United States was rocketing ahead on clean energy projects, pushed by government, and oil industry executives were brimming with optimism amid record production.

Companies are opting not to add new wells out of fear they will lose money. The number of active rigs in Texas is lower now than it has been since the nation was climbing out of the pandemic. The president's tariffs are meanwhile driving up costs in U.S. oil fields, leaving firms hesitant to invest in expanding production.

"It is truly affecting everybody," said T. Grant Johnson, president of Lone Star Production Company, an oil exploration firm in Texas. "There was a lot of talk of, 'drill baby, drill.' But these companies are not going to drill if the economics aren't there. All this fear and uncertainty is causing people to be far more cautious."

SEE ENERGY ON A7

Nuclear energy: Trump weighs new rules in bid for more plants. **A5**

Leo's ascent occurred with remarkable speed. Two years ago, he was one of the church's 5,400 bishops with no global visibility.



FRANCESCO SFORZA/VATICAN MEDIA/REUTERS

Modest missionary now His Holiness

BY CHICO HARLAN, SAMANTHA SCHMIDT, KIM BELLWARE AND BIANCA PADRÓ OCASIO

Two-and-a-half years ago, Pope Francis was trying to fill a big job. For decades, that position — heading the powerful office that helps vet and select bishops — had gone to consummate Vatican insiders. But Francis had staked his papacy on expanding the boundaries of the Catholic Church. And he had his eye on a surprise contender: an American-born missionary operating in the coastal plains of Peru, some 6,000 miles from Rome.

"You know that I am very happy in Peru," the missionary, then-Bishop Robert Prevost, recalled telling Francis. "But if you ask me to take on a new role in the church, I will accept."



PAUL SUNCION/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

FROM TOP: Pope Leo XIV visits the Sanctuary of the Mother of Good Counsel in Genazzano, Rome, on Saturday. Bishop Robert Prevost last year during a visit to Chulucanas, Peru.

"Pray that I make a good decision," Francis said, according to Prevost's recollection.

In selecting Prevost for that job, Francis fast-tracked the career of the man who'd ultimately become his successor and provided a crucial step in what has now become a singular life path: from Chicago's suburbs to Latin America to the frescoed halls of power in Vatican City, and finally to the very pinnacle of the Roman Catholic Church.

Elected Thursday as Pope Leo XIV, Prevost has become the first pontiff born in the United States

SEE POPE ON A10

'Da Pope': Chicagoans bask in a deep sense of hometown pride. **A9**

Trump heralds Pakistan, India deal

U.S. STEPS IN AFTER DAYS OF ESCALATION

Both sides already claim violations of fragile truce

BY KARISHMA MEHROTRA, RICK NOACK AND NATALIE ALLISON

NEW DELHI — Over four nerve-racking nights, missiles and drones streaked across the skies of major cities in India and Pakistan, as the nuclear-armed neighbors appeared to be sliding toward all-out war. Then, seemingly out of nowhere, President Donald Trump announced a truce.

"India and Pakistan have agreed to a FULL AND IMMEDIATE CEASEFIRE," Trump posted to Truth Social on Saturday, saying the deal had been reached "after a long night of talks mediated by the United States."

The sudden announcement of a U.S.-brokered ceasefire followed four days of steady escalation between the regional rivals, and mixed signals from Washington over whether it would reprise its traditional role as mediator.

Amid celebrations in India and Pakistan on Saturday, and self-congratulations in Washington, Kashmir endured another night of violence, with both sides claiming violations — a grim reminder that the deal seems to have only temporarily contained one of the world's longest-running conflicts rather than ended it.

A person familiar with the situation, who like others in this article spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive negotiations, said Vice President JD Vance called Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi around noon in Washington on Friday after senior U.S. officials became increasingly worried about the spiraling situation.

The person said Vance provided Modi with a potential "off-ramp" that U.S. officials understood Pakistani officials would be willing to accept. Over the next

SEE CEASEFIRE ON A17

Explosions: More shelling reported after ceasefire was to take hold. **A17**

Trump's trade war splinters staff at 'Pencil City' factory

Politics rarely came up in this Bible Belt town. Then, the president used pencils to sell tariffs.

BY EMILY DAVIES

SHELBYVILLE, TENN. — Inside one of the nation's last surviving pencil manufacturers, Jason Glines heaved slats of wood imported from China through a cutting machine. He watched as blades grooved the poplar, among the first steps in an assembly line that, until last month, felt American enough.

Before this year, politics rarely came up on the production floor at Musgrave Pencil Company, located in a town once known as "Pencil City." President Donald Trump's tariff policies have changed that.

With orders down and grocery prices up, some employees quietly worry the president's trade war will hurt their jobs, which have grown dependent on a global supply chain stymied by the tariffs. Others, including Glines, talk openly about how Trump makes sense when he talks about "winning," especially against other countries.

SEE PENCIL CITY ON A18



KEVIN WURM/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

David Mortimer, 49, works in the wood department of Musgrave Pencil Company in Shelbyville, Tennessee. Musgrave erasers, graphite cores and wood are mostly from China.

Japanese American GIs are feted as 'saviors' 80 years on

Facing bias at home, the 'nisei' liberated Jews from a Nazi death march

BY ELLEN NAKASHIMA

WAAKIRCHEN, GERMANY — Eighty years ago, Abba Naor was among several thousand Jews and other prisoners evacuated from Nazi concentration camps and forced to walk for days on the notorious Dachau death march — without food or water, often in freezing temperatures. Many perished on the way.

On the eighth night, as snow fell and covered the exhausted prisoners, their SS guards — fearing the fast-approaching Allies — vanished.

The following morning, American soldiers appeared. But when Naor looked up, the faces he saw were unlike any he had seen before. They were Japanese American soldiers, part of a storied

military unit that faced down prejudice and suspicion to fight Adolf Hitler's armies in Europe. Some of them had family members imprisoned in internment camps in the western United States.

On May 2, Naor returned to a clearing here in a Bavarian forest, where he and some 2,700 others were liberated, to pay homage to the American GIs who aided him and his fellow survivors. A memorial plaque was unveiled to commemorate the actions of the soldiers, who were the sons of immigrants from Japan — second-generation Americans, or "nisei."

"They were angels for us," said Naor, 97, who was born in Lithuania and now lives in Israel.

The tale of the 522nd Field Artillery Battalion, an all-nisei combat unit, is little known but highlights the diversity of Americans who fought against totalitarianism, and serves as a reminder of America's long commitment to the defense of Europe at a time when U.S. assurances no longer

SEE SOLDIERS ON A14

BOOK WORLD

Chilean novelist Isabel Allende's home library has what matters most.

ARTS & STYLE

Trump's theater dreams get a second act with Kennedy Center coup.

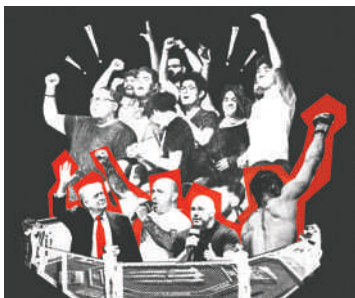


DINING GUIDE

Tom Sietsema's top 20 best new places to eat in the D.C. region.

BUSINESS

3D printing is shaking up the space industry and how rockets are made.



SPORTS

A weekend of violence and "escape" in Vegas with the fan-bros of UFC.

TRAVEL

El Salvador takes in America's prisoners and wants its tourists, too.

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SUNDAY COUPON INSERTS

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